

FOOD TOUR

HANOI: THREE HOURS, FOUR DISHES

VIETNAM



Vietnam

WHERE ON EARTH

HANOI

Three hours, four dishes

by WAHEEDA HARRIS



PHOTO THIS SPREAD
Fresh fruit vendor on
the street in Hanoi.



«ONCE THE SUN SETS, Hanoi is focused on one thing: dinner. In the popular Old Quarter, I'm on a walking food tour with the Hanoi Cooking Centre and the street sounds are triggering my hunger pangs. I hear bursts of steam, the scrape of cooking utensils against pots, and tidbits of overheard conversation as diners decide between their many options.



But I'm lucky — thanks to my tour company, Travel for Travellers by GLP Worldwide, the Hanoi Cooking Centre guide will be making the choices for the dine around. I'll be tasting two quintessential Vietnamese dishes and two beloved dishes from Hanoi.

Goi du du kho bo — Green papaya salad at Nom Thit Bo Kho

A ten-minute walk from my hotel brings the tour to its first stop: a typical Vietnamese sidewalk restaurant with fluorescent lighting and rows of plastic stools. The first rule of sidewalk dining: how to gracefully sit on a small, short-legged stool. If you're used to a table and chairs, traditional dining in Hanoi will provide daily opportunity to learn how to squat gracefully, which I fail on my first try. After laughing at myself and finding a way to sit, I focus on tasting *du du*, aka papaya, prettily piled on a bright blue plate.

Crisp, fresh and spicy, *goi du du kho bo* takes advantage of the bold raw flavours of unripened fruit. One of the not-so-secret tips of Asian cooking is the benefit of using ingredients at different stages of growth. Although the typical fixation is on ripe fruit, using green papaya provides a tangy and slightly sweet flavour to contrast with the dressing — sugar, vinegar, soy, water and a thinly sliced chili. The papaya is grated into long threads and combined with fresh coriander, mint, skinny strands of dried beef and chopped peanuts for a salad that hits all the flavour profiles. It's a hallmark of restaurant menus, and I wish I could have more, but I know there are more dishes coming.»



PHOTO THIS SPREAD
CLOCKWISE FROM BOTTOM
LEFT Breakfast in the
street; Rickshaw Hanoi;
Green papaya salad at
Nom Thit Bo Kho.



DAVID MCKELVEY

Ca phe trung — Egg coffee at Café Giang

Another short walk through the Old Quarter leads to a narrow doorway with a small sign, a bland beige hallway and a small counter to order. There's no glass-covered case with baked goods or endless menu of coffee and milk options. But there is the familiarity of a coffee house — quiet conversation between patrons, and individuals multitasking, sipping and fixating on their mobile phones. What's on offer here is a hit of java the Vietnamese way. Invented in Hanoi by a chef at the Sofitel Metropole Hotel, *ca phe trung* is now found all through the city. But is more than just coffee and milk.

Ca phe trung is heady mixture of strong dark coffee, topped with a custard made from egg yolk and sweet condensed milk. It's half-and-half the Vietnamese way, with a healthy dose of soft yellow custard, twice as creamy as any foam I've ever had. I treat this more like a dessert, starting with spoonfuls of custard before I begin sipping the coffee. It's not the typical jolt of caffeine, but it's definitely a memorable taste that has washed away the salty spicy notes of the papaya salad and prepared me ready for a quintessential taste of this country.

Banh mi — sandwich at Banh Mi 25

Our next walk passes along Beer Street, a lively string of bars where the patios are crowded with 20-something locals and backpackers, happily sharing pitchers of cold beer and swapping stories. Each pub belts out hip hop, K-pop, dance or classic rock, all mixing into an overwhelming cacophony that quickly fades as we turn down another side street and discover a residential neighbourhood with a small area highlighted by the illuminated sign of Banh Mi 25. Although there's a lengthy list of banh mi combinations, we're having the local favourite, one that isn't listed, as it's the standard.

The French brought the baguette to Vietnam when it was a colony and banh mi (which translates to bread) is one of the few tasty and welcome legacies of that time period. Considered a breakfast option in Vietnam, the sandwich has become a popular offering around the world. The standard is this: a fresh baguette, with its distinctive crust and soft interior is generously filled with a combination of crunchy, salty and spicy fillings: long strips of cucumber and carrot, fresh mint and cilantro leaves, pickled radish, liver pâté and a generous portion of spicy slices of pork. Wrapped in brown paper, the sandwich is familiar yet new to me. The ingredients seem more potent here, and as I sit on my stool and happily consume my banh mi, I relish the sour flavours of the pickles with the boldness of the cilantro. I'm considering ordering one to go, joining the steady stream of customers who wait a few minutes and stroll off with their tasty takeaway. But there's one last treat on the tour to be had.

Cha ca la vong — turmeric fish at Tom 9 Cha Ca

The last stop leads us farther into the Old Quarter, with no tourists to be seen. I hear snippets of TV laugh tracks drifting from open windows, as families relax in their living rooms. Historic Hang Ba Street, known for its silk shops, is now without any shoppers but there's a light at the entry to Tom 9 Cha Ca, a family home that doubles as a restaurant. Climbing two flights of steep stairs, we gather around a table with wooden chairs instead of stools. A family

...It's not the typical
jolt of caffeine...



KRISTA



WAHNEE HARRIS

shrine to Buddha sits above as we wait for our final taste of the city and a hallmark of Hanoi cuisine, *Cha ca la vong* — turmeric fish with herbs.

As bowls and chopsticks are delivered and drink orders taken, the bare wood table is soon crowded with small bowls of green onions, cilantro, sliced chilis, peanuts, vinegar sauce and rice. Another silver platter arrives, sizzling with chunks of bright yellow fish, cooking in bubbling peanut oil. I'm instructed to toss the onions on top and as they wilt from the heat, there's an aromatic flourish before I taste the soft, gently spiced fish with a spoonful of white rice. I generously add peanuts, cilantro and vinegar sauce, but I'm more cautious with the chilis, knowing these small slivers could pack a mighty punch of spicy heat.

Four places, four tastes of Vietnam — all complex and yet so simple — relying on fresh and locally sourced ingredients and combinations that always offer more than one flavour. Salty, sweet, sour, spicy — my palate has had a welcome workout as I wandered through the streets of Hanoi. 



PHOTO THIS SPREAD
CLOCKWISE FROM
TOP LEFT Egg
coffee; Toppings
for turmeric fish;
Turmeric fish at
Tom 9 Cha Ca;
Banh mi.

WAHEEDA HARRIS



WAHEEDA HARRIS

Cook
&

SERVES 2

Goi Du Du Green Papaya Salad

THIS RECIPE comes from the Hanoi Cooking Centre. Look for green papaya in an Asian supermarket. If you can't find it, you can substitute julienne strips of zucchini or chayote, tossed with the juice of a lime.

Salad

Green Papaya ½, peeled and julienned
Carrot 1 small, peeled and julienned
Lemon Balm ½ cup
Dried Beef Jerky a few strips, shredded
Roasted Peanuts 1 Tbs, chopped
Fresh Cilantro Leaves for garnish

Bun Cha Sauce

Water 315 ml
Fish Sauce 2 ½ Tbs
Rice Vinegar 2 ½ Tbs
White Sugar 5 Tbs
Palm Sugar or **Brown Sugar** 1 tsp

- 1 COMBINE** all the sauce ingredients in a saucepan and boil until the sugar is dissolved.
- 2 COMBINE** the papaya, carrot, lemon balm and dried beef with the sauce. Top with cilantro and peanuts.

Do
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In addition to street food and market walking tours, Hanoi Cooking Centre offers a licensed café open to the public and hands-on cooking classes and workshops designed by Tracey Lister, Australian chef and co-author with Andreas Pohl of three books

Vietnamese cookbooks: *Koto* (2011), *Real Vietnamese Cooking* (2014) and *Vietnamese Street Food* (2016).
www.hanoicookingcentre.com

Freelance journalist **WAHEEDA HARRIS** has been fortunate to explore six of the seven continents, happy to learn the culture, music, style and cuisine intrinsic to each, and ensuring her hot sauce collection keeps growing.